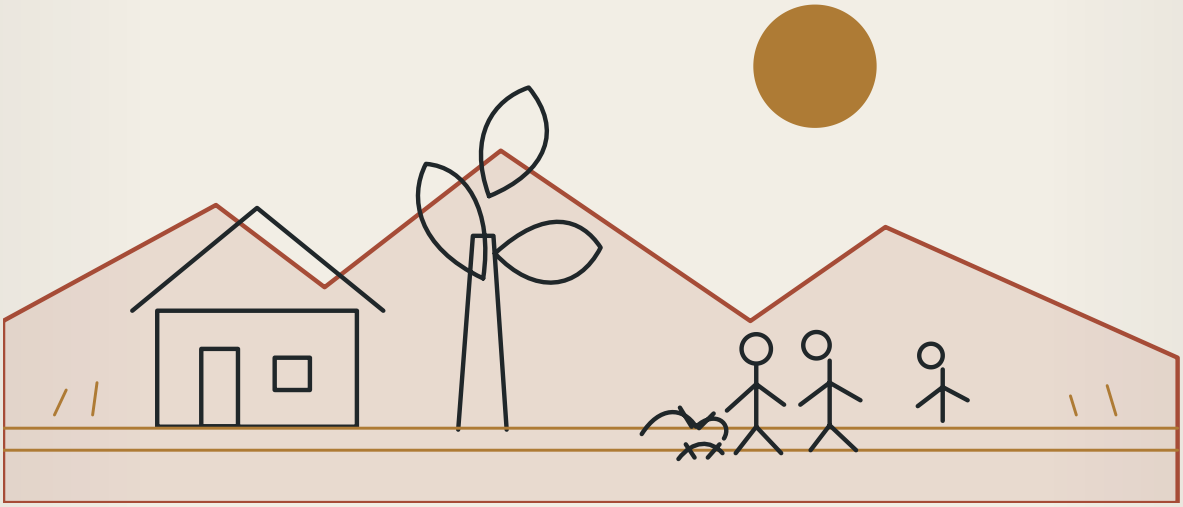
A TIV STORY / A LITERARY BROCHURE

The Infested *Land*

A story of hospitality, disrespect, consequence, and the long work of gathering a people back together.

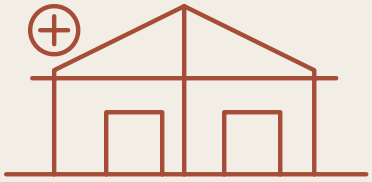


CREATIVE WRITING BY **BENJAMIN ARMSTRONG ZUGU**

PUBLISHED BY EGWUATU DEMION IKENNA

01

THE LAND BEFORE THE RATS



In those days that Ulu was the orya (head of the family) of Kange, Uwouku Abanka was the tyoor (clanhead) of Saghev and Alfred Akaweh Torkula was the TorTiv (king of Tiv) people, a strange epidemic befell the land of Kange and Gbise.

A story is usually told of these two brothers who never agreed with each other, and although they stayed not far apart, there was no form of hospitality between them that was not accompanied with insults. The story has it that Gbise was favoured more by the gods and because of this, he used to see his brother Kange as a failure and taunted him at the slightest opportunity which presented itself. He could taunt him by saying people from his brother's house, "ya u za yav, ne mba a kwaghyan ga," which loosely translated means "eat and go and sleep, your people don't have food."

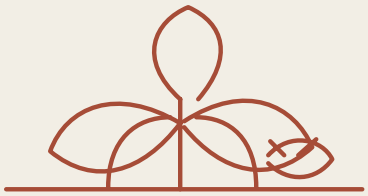
This happened at a time when Tiv people were known for and valued hospitality so much. Food was eaten in the Ate, a reception hall, so that any passer-by could partake in the meals, uninvited. In fact, whoever had no reception hall was said to be stingy and not worthy of a visit, as he would not want to share his meals. These constant humiliations from his

brother therefore led Kange to do something that changed the course of his life. But that is a story for another day.

While Ulu Kange was the head of the Kange family, he abhorred evil and ensured discipline and respect for elders were held in high esteem; anyone seen violating them was severely dealt with. Notwithstanding his stance on discipline and respect, some youth chose the wayward path and this almost wrecked the peaceful existence of the entire village.

02

AKOODO'S DECLARATION



In the whole of Saghev clan, Akoodo was known for his powers of wizardry and sorcery; on several occasions, he was accused of killing innocent people through witchcraft and was summarily banished from the land, as the brothers refused to have his blood on their heads. This was the very man the youth of Kange annoyed, and he almost ruined their existence.

It happened on a hot Saturday afternoon, when the youth went to inspect their traps for possible game. They met Akoodo after they had checked their traps and caught some rats. They greeted him warmly and respectfully:

> *"ortamen u pande nena?"*
>
> (elder, how are you doing?)

> *"mngu gbangbang, kwahg erem ga. Ne ye?"*
>
> (I am doing well. How about you?)

> *"se kpa se mba gbanggbang, kwagh er se ga cii."*
>
> (We are doing well too.)

Concluding that the exchange of pleasantries and their duty to an elder was done, they proceeded home, as the sun was already hurrying behind the clouds to rest. But Akoodo was not done with them. He requested the young men to share what they caught from the hunt with him, as he did not catch anything that day. They respectfully declined, telling him that it was not enough even for their family meals.

Akoodo was enraged at their response and made a declaration: “er ne nyumem ihyev nahan, ka ihyev tseegh ne ya ye.” This translates to: “since you refused to give me the rats, it’s only rats that you will eat.” He immediately squatted on the ground and released the rats.

03

THE LAND IS OVERRUN



What ensued was an epidemic of rats. They appeared in thousands everywhere: at home, on the farms, and in market stores. It was said that any hole that could inhabit them held thousands; a single hole could yield up to three hundred rats. They destroyed farm products and the ones stored at home in barns and stores, thus resulting in a serious famine.

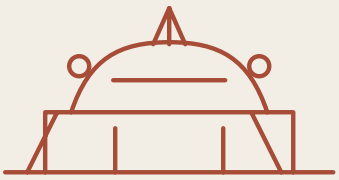
At first, the people decided to eat them in order to reduce their numbers. This did not go well, as the smell or aroma of the rats became unbearable for them. The elders therefore came together to seek for a permanent solution.

After their deliberations, a delegation was sent to Atongee, the eye of the gods, to know why such a calamity had befallen them. The gods, through Atongee, revealed that the curse was from Akoodo due to his anger at the children's denial to give him what they caught.

At the revelation, Akoodo was contacted by the elders to know what could be done to appease him. When he received the delegation, he was just warming up to take his final evening meal of the day and rest.

04

MERCY, LESSON, RETURN



After pleasantries, one of the elders went straight to the point, pleading with him that the children of these days were disrespectful and full of mischief, but urging him to temper justice with mercy:

> *"a lu wan nyia u sha nam yo, u gberen ku u te kera ga, kpa u dindeh a dindeh"*
>
> (if a child defecates on your lap, you don't cut it and throw it away, you rob it).

He pleaded and inquired what could be done to appease him. In response, Akoodo demanded that the young men who denied him that game must present him with two dozen each of roasted rats and kneel before him for him to lift the curse.

The delegation wasted no time, but returned to give their message to the elders, despite the encouragement from Akoodo to share in his evening meal. The young men were summoned and told what to do. Since rats were readily available, they gathered the required dozen and the next morning were at Akoodo's house to present them.

When they arrived, they fell on the ground, pleaded for mercy, and presented the rats to him. He therefore collected them and lifted the curse of the rats on the land through some inaudible incantations and libations, telling them he was sure that they had learnt their lesson.

This singular act robbed many of their loved ones and livelihoods, and they went back to living their normal lives again, picking the pieces that were left behind.

— end —

THE INFESTED LAND

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